

Low-Nickel Diet



What is it?

People with allergic contact dermatitis can be so sensitive to their allergen that they must avoid skin exposure AND ingestion (eating) of the chemical. This type of allergy could cause dermatitis on the hands, face, around the mouth, or at the skin folds (armpits, groin). Some people may have dermatitis all over their bodies.

For some people allergic to nickel, a diet low in nickel can reduce the likelihood of skin reactions. The level of nickel required to produce a response is unknown and can vary from patient to patient. A two-month trial of removing foods and beverages that contain nickel is recommended.

The goal is a low-nickel diet. In general, avoid anything with beans, chocolate, peanuts, soy, oatmeal, or granola.

There are three methods to avoid nickel in your diet:

- Use the free app “Nickel Navigator”
- Use the table below to count points
- Choose foods from a low-nickel cookbook

Low Nickel Cookbooks:

- The Low Nickel Diet Cookbook & Guide: A Holistic Approach to Systemic Nickel Allergy by Duzett & Zirwas
- Low nickel diet cookbook for living without nickel: the complete guide with 640 Recipes and Practical Solutions for an Allergy-Free Life by Santamaria
- Super easy low nickel Prep for Beginners: Simple Meal Plans and Prep Strategies for a Healthy, Nickel-Conscious Lifestyle by Queen

Additional Treatment Options:

In some cases where you have a severe allergy, you might need additional measures to avoid nickel. Ask your healthcare provider if these options are right for you:

- Vitamin C: take a chewable 500-mg or 1000-mg vitamin C tablet with every meal to help prevent nickel from being absorbed. It must be taken at the beginning, middle, or end of each meal. The vitamin C must be in the stomach at the same time as the food.
- Consume only bottled/distilled water, either by drinking or in cooking.
- Avoid cooking acidic foods in stainless steel cookware. Acidic foods include tomatoes, vinegar, and citrus. Safe types of cookware are nonstick coated aluminum, copper, and cast iron.
- Avoid multivitamins or supplements that could contain nickel.
- Disulfuram has been reported to be helpful for patients with systemic nickel allergy but must be used with caution because people who take this medication can become violently ill if they consume alcohol.
- Oral disodium cromoglycolate has been reported to be helpful for patients with dyshidrotic eczema and nickel allergy.

References

1. *Dermatitis*. 2013;24:190-195
2. *Contact Dermatitis*. 1990 Jan;22:27-31
3. *Dermatitis*. 2011 Sep-Oct;22:251-5

In addition, the ACDS Contact Allergen Management Program® (CAMP®) can help manage contact dermatitis. It helps to find products that are safe to use by creating a list of products that do not contain one's allergens. For more information about CAMP®, please ask your doctor or visit www.contactderm.org.

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More detailed instructions for a low-nickel diet¹:

1. Adults should consume no more than 15 points per day.
2. Children younger than 12 years should consume no more than 10 points per day.
3. Very rare individuals are even more sensitive than this and may need to stay under 5 points per day.
4. Each food item listed below represents one typical U.S.-based portion.

0 Point Foods					
Apple	0	Eggs	0	Mushrooms	0
Beer	0	Fruit drink	0	Olive oil	0
Butter or margarine	0	Half and half cream	0	Popsicle	0
Candy, hard	0	Honey	0	Salad dressing	0
Cheese, cheddar	0	Ice cream, vanilla	0	Soda/pop/cola	0
Cheese, Swiss	0	Jello	0	Sour cream	0
Chicken breast, skin removed	0	Jelly	0	Steak	0
Coffee creamer, nondairy	0	Lunch meat (chicken, turkey, ham)	0	Sugar	0
Cottage cheese	0	Maple syrup	0	Tuna, canned	0
Cream cheese	0	Mayonnaise	0	Vegetable oil	0
Eggplant	0	Milk, white	0		
1 Point Foods					
Apple juice	1	Collards	1	Onion	1
Applesauce	1	Cookies, sugar	1	Orange	1
Bacon	1	Corn/hominy grits	1	Orange juice	1
Bagel, plain	1	Cornbread	1	Pickles, dill	1
Banana	1	Crackers (non-whole wheat)	1	Pork chop	1
Beets	1	Cranberry juice cocktail	1	Pork roast	1
Bologna	1	Cucumber	1	Potato chips	1
Bread, white	1	English muffin, plain	1	Pretzels	1
Broccoli	1	Fruit juice blend	1	Raisins	1
Brussel sprouts	1	Grape juice	1	Rice, white	1

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Cabbage	1	Grapefruit	1	Sausage	1
Carrot	1	Grapes	1	Sherbet	1
Cauliflower	1	Gravy, canned or bottled	1	Shrimp	1
Celery	1	Ham, cured, baked	1	Soup, oriental noodles (ramen)	1
Cereal, corn flakes	1	Hotdog	1	Spaghetti	1
Cereal, cream of wheat	1	Lamb chop	1	Spaghetti with meat sauce	1
Cereal, raisin bran cereal	1	Lemonade	1	Squash, summer	1
Cereal, shredded wheat	1	Liver (beef/calf)	1	Sweet and sour sauce	1
Cheese, American, processed	1	Lunch meat, salami	1	Tomato	1
Chicken breast, fried with skin	1	Macaroni and cheese	1	Tomato catsup	1
Chicken leg, fried with skin	1	Macaroni salad	1	Tomato salsa, bottled	1
Chicken, roasted skinless	1	Meatloaf	1	Tortilla chips, corn	1
Chuck roast, beef	1	Muffin, fruit or plain	1	Turkey breast	1
Coffee	1	Noodles, egg	1	Turnip	1
Coffee, decaffeinated	1	Okra	1	Wine, red/white	1
Coleslaw	1	Olives	1	Yellow mustard	1
2 Point Foods					
Apple pie	2	English muffin: egg, cheese, ham	2	Potato salad	2
Avocado	2	Fish sandwich, fast food	2	Potato, baked or boiled	2
Biscuits	2	Fish sticks or patty	2	Pudding, not chocolate	2
Bread, wheat or rye	2	Grapefruit juice	2	Soup, chicken noodle, canned	2
Cake, yellow with icing	2	Green beans	2	Spinach	2
Candy bar, chocolate, nougat, nuts	2	Hamburger	2	Squash, winter	2
Cantaloupe	2	Lettuce	2	Strawberries	2
Catfish	2	Pancakes	2	Sweet potatoes	2
Cereal, crisped rice	2	Peanuts	2	Sweet roll/Danish pastry	2

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Chicken filet sandwich-broiled	2	Pear	2	Tea, decaffeinated	2
Chocolate chip cookies	2	Pepper, green	2	Tea, from tea bag	2
Cookies (Oreo type)	2	Popcorn	2	Tortilla, flour	2
Corn	2	Pop tart/toaster pastry	2	Yogurt	2
3-4 Point Foods					
Apricots	3	Pineapple	3	Watermelon	3
Asparagus	3	Pizza, cheese and pepperoni	3	Beef with vegetables in sauce	4
Beef stroganoff with noodles	3	Pumpkin pie	3	Chicken potpie, frozen	4
Cereal, fruit flavored	3	Rice, fried and meatless	3	Clam chowder	4
Chicken nuggets, fast food	3	Soup, vegetable beef, canned	3	French fries	4
Chicken with vegetables in sauce	3	Stew - beef and vegetable	3	Fruit cocktail, canned	4
Doughnut	3	Taco/tostada with beef and cheese	3	Milk, chocolate	4
Meal replacement shake	3	Tomato sauce, bottled	3	Peas, frozen	4
Peach	3	Tuna noodle casserole	3	Soup, tomato, canned	4
Peanut butter	3	Vegetables, mixed	3	Tomato juice	4
5-10 Point Foods / AVOID (X)					
Granola bar with raisins	5	Lasagna with meat	7	Cereal, oat ring	X
Beans, white	6	Prune juice	7	Chili with beans, canned	X
Brownie	6	Burrito (beef, beans, cheese)	8	Lima beans	X
Cereal, granola with raisins	6	Milk shake, chocolate	8	Pinto beans	X
Chocolate	6	Oatmeal	9	Pork and beans	X
Chocolate syrup	6	Soup (bean, bacon, pork), canned	10	Refried beans	X
Pineapple juice	6	Cake, chocolate with icing	X	Sunflower seeds, shelled	X

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